

What Presence stands for

The values behind the product, derived from the objectives and rules already decided — written so that every future decision, feature, partner and line of code can be checked against them.

Version 1.0 · 12 September 2026 · applies to every Presence track (careers, students) and to the brand

Mission

Give people who are looking for work — or preparing for it — a capable companion they own outright: one that works for them every day, tells them the truth, keeps their data at home, and never costs them the money they are trying to earn.

Presence exists because the people who need this help most — job seekers, students, people between things — are exactly the people who cannot pay for it, and are exactly the people whose data the existing tools quietly harvest. The answer is not a cheaper subscription. It is a tool they run themselves.

Who we serve

A student in their final year with no idea where the next step comes from. A graduate on a visa clock. Anyone doing the long, repetitive, demoralising work of finding a job while money runs down. And — through the student track — anyone in the years before that, trying to study well, set goals and keep a routine. We build for the person at the kitchen table, not for the recruiter, the platform, or the investor.

The eight values

1. The human decides

Presence finds, prepares, reminds and coaches. It never applies, submits, sends or posts on a person's behalf — **a human clicks every Submit**. It never defeats a website's bot protection or rate limits, because a companion that sneaks is not one you can trust with your name.

In practice: there is no code path that submits an application; the test suite enforces it; a pull request that adds one is declined regardless of quality.

2. Truth over polish

Nothing Presence says about you is invented. Facts come from what you stated or what was extracted and you confirmed. Drafts never contain a number, employer, skill or achievement you did not give. Progress reports say what happened, including failures.

In practice: an unconfirmed profile is refused at load; writers are grounded in confirmed facts only; run reports list what was skipped and why. This value came from the author's own job hunt, where the rule "never overclaim" was worth more than any template.

3. Your data stays yours

Your CV, profile, tracker and credentials live on your machine. No telemetry, no analytics phoning home, no cloud account to create. Where Presence reads your mailbox, the access is read-only by construction. The code is open so that this claim can be checked rather than believed.

4. Free where it matters

Everything essential is free, forever. No tiers, no monthly fee, no "pro" gate in front of the features that get someone a job. Presence is funded by the people it has helped, voluntarily, after the fact — and by anything that is genuinely extra: hosted convenience, setup help, sponsor credit. The moment a feature is essential, it is free.

In practice: the pricing page says "\$0 — you're job hunting, keep your money." The zero-cost path (free software plus a free local model) is a tested, first-class configuration, so even model costs cannot become a hidden subscription.

5. Small core, open edges

The engine interprets only what it must; everything else is a pack, a plugin, or a field it stores and never reads. Sims, drills, prompts and connectors are plain-text packs anyone can edit and share under MIT. Presence is a customisable ecosystem, not a service — it should fit a person's life, not the other way round.

6. No surprises

A companion that runs unattended must be boring in the right ways: it never corrupts your records, it fails softly when a source is down, it stops and says so when the daily spending cap is reached, it survives a laptop closing, and its status is always one message away.

7. Built by the people it serves

Presence was built by a graduate who needed it, on his own job hunt, and he remains user number one. The student track is built by a student. Design decisions come from real use first, evidence second, opinion last — the dedupe rules, the timeline format, the "one action today" brief all came from lived weeks, not whiteboards.

8. Respect for the other side

Employers, job boards and recruiters are not targets. Presence is polite to the sources it reads — one query at a time, as an ordinary client — and it never mass-applies. Spray-and-pray wastes everyone's time, including the applicant's; it is the very thing Presence refuses to become.

What we are not

- **Not an auto-applier.** The category is crowded, low-trust and increasingly resented by employers. We are the opposite of it.
- **Not a data business.** There is nothing to harvest because nothing leaves the machine.
- **Not a subscription.** Essential features will never move behind a paywall — a promise, not a pricing experiment.
- **Not a replacement for judgment.** Presence prepares the decision; the person makes it.

Decision rules

When two options both seem reasonable, these settle it:

When in doubt...	...choose
Precision or recall?	Precision. Never swallow a real posting, never merge two different jobs, never act on an uncertain fact. A missed duplicate costs a glance; a lost opportunity costs a chance.

Convenience or the charter?	The charter. Convenience features that weaken any of the four rules are declined.
Feature or simplicity?	Simplicity in the core; the feature becomes a pack or plugin if it earns its place.
Free or paid?	Free if a person needs it to get the job. Paid only if it is provably extra.
Speak or stay quiet?	Speak for time-sensitive things (an interview invite), stay quiet for the rest until the daily brief. Attention is the user's scarcest resource.
Ship or measure?	Measure — an eval, a real-data run, a beta week — when the question is about judgment quality; ship when it is about plumbing.

How the values become real

- The four charter rules live in `CHARTER.md` and in tests; CI fails if they are weakened.
- Contribution rules say it plainly: pull requests that weaken a value are declined regardless of technical quality.
- The brand (logo, voice, style) must express these values — calm, honest, on the person's side — and never borrow the urgency and hype of the tools we refuse to be.
- This document is versioned. Changing a value is a public decision with a written reason, not a quiet edit.